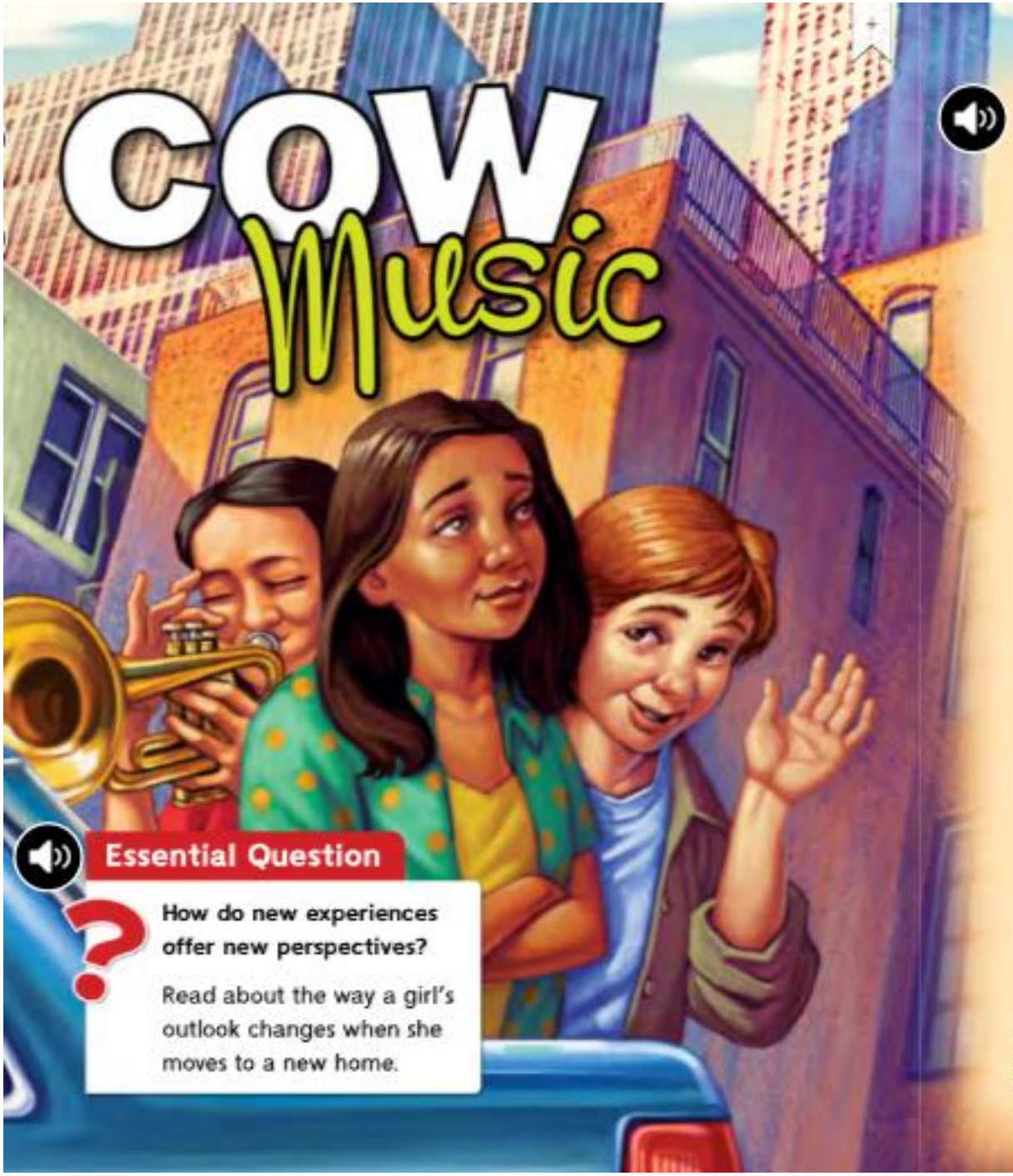


COW Music

Essential Question

How do new experiences offer new perspectives?

Read about the way a girl's outlook changes when she moves to a new home.

Farewell to Me

I crammed one last box into the back seat and slammed the car door. It felt as if I were slamming the door on my whole life. At first, I was thrilled when Mom told me she'd gotten a fantastic new job as a veterinarian at an animal hospital. Then, because she always saves the bad news for last, she told me the really **heinous** part. The hospital wasn't in our city; it was miles away in the middle of nowhere. And I'm definitely *not* a country girl.

I slouched against the car, taking a last look at our building. To most people, it probably just looks like any other old apartment house, but I love every grimy brick. Soon I'd be staring at piles of hay.

Just then, I heard a bright blast of music and saw my best friends, Hana and Leo, come charging up to me. While Hana played a cool riff on her trumpet, Leo sang, "We will miss you, Celia . . . At least you won't be in Australia." I raised my eyebrows.

Laughing, Leo said, "Hey, *you* find something to rhyme with *Celia*!"

"You guys are utterly **indispensable!**" I blurted out. "How will I live without you?"

"Ever hear of texting?" asked Hana, punctuating her question with a loud trumpet honk. I jumped into the car fast so no one could see me tear up. As Mom pulled away, I waved goodbye to my friends, my neighborhood, and my life.

We rode a while in silence, and I wedged my violin case beneath my legs for comfort. Leo, Hana, and I had been writing songs for our band, but that was all over now. "Don't think of this as an ending," Mom said, with her knack for reading my mind. "It's an exciting beginning, and we're on the **threshold** of a breathtaking new adventure."

"Yeah, it'll be great. I couldn't be happier," I said glumly.

"Don't be **sarcastic**, *mija*," Mom said. "It's so unattractive."

©Greg Newbold

Being attractive wasn't a big goal at the moment, but annoying Mom wasn't either. So I clammed up and looked out the window as crowded, exciting city streets turned first into bland suburban shopping strips and then into endless, boring trees and fields of corn.

"Look: cows!" Mom said, as we cruised past some black-and-white blotches in a pasture.

"Sure, they seem sweet," I said, "but I bet they have a mean streak when you're not looking."

"It's normal to be a bit **phobic** about unfamiliar things," Mom said, in her best patient-parent tone. "But you don't need to be afraid of cows. They're harmless."

"Harmless . . . and boring," I thought to myself. "Like everything in the country."

Not So Bad?

We finally arrived at our new home, a two-story wooden farmhouse. It had a crooked roof, a rickety front porch, and too many places for bats to hide. "Would you mind if I don't go in yet?" I asked.

Mom looked overwhelmed. She just nodded and said I could go explore. I felt a **glimmer** of hope, a small hint that country life might turn out okay. Mom never let me go out alone in the city, so maybe a bit more freedom would be one **consolation** of living here.

I wandered off, clutching my violin and not paying attention to where I was going. It didn't matter; it was all just a blur of green and brown. I imagined that a big Saturday night here meant sitting around talking about corn . . . or watching it grow.



Suddenly I heard something I wasn't expecting—a blaring, jazzy tune. I pushed through some corn only to come face-to-face with an enormous cow. Then another hot jazz riff floated through the air. I spun around and saw a tall kid playing a beat-up old saxophone in the clearing. His music was fantastic, and he didn't dress the way I figured a country kid would. Where were the muddy dungarees and plaid bandana? This guy was wearing clothes that made him look cool, like a famous performer.

Not Bad at All!

I couldn't resist, so I took out my violin and began to play along. The boy looked surprised, but he didn't miss a beat. We improvised a cool duet, and by the end—no kidding—the big cow's tail was swishing to the rhythm. "I'm Jason," he said when we finished. "I play out here because the cows don't complain when I mess up. You must be Celia. My dad said you were moving in. I can't believe you play violin! I've been looking for someone to write songs with."

I looked at Jason and his dented sax, the cheerful cow and tall corn, the majestic trees in the distance, and the sun shining in the brilliant blue sky. I could feel my **perception** of country life already changing, and I had a feeling it would change a lot more.



Summarize

Use your notes to orally summarize the story. Be sure to include details about the key events in the story and how the main character changes. Talk about whether your prediction from page 34 was confirmed or if it needed correction.